

HiveForce Labs

THREAT ADVISORY



ATTACK REPORT

VECT Ransomware: Flawed Encryption Turns RaaS Locker into Irreversible File Wiper

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April 30, 2026

Admiralty Code

A1

TA Number

TA2026117

Summary

First Seen: December 2025

Targeted Regions: United States, Brazil, India, South Africa, Israel, Panama, Ecuador, Egypt, Colombia, Spain, Italy, Namibia, Peru, Mozambique

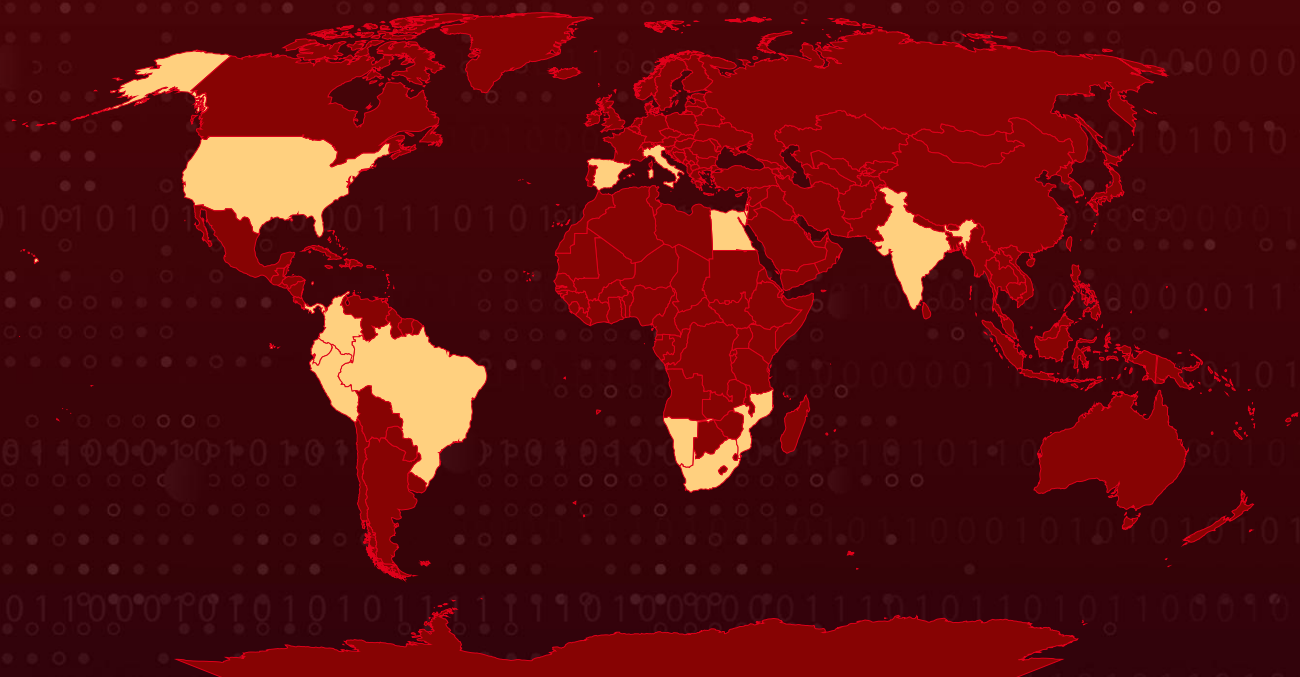
Targeted Platforms: Windows, Linux, VMware ESXi

Targeted Industries: Technology, Manufacturing, Financial Services, Healthcare, Business Services, Engineering Services, Education, Real Estate, Forestry & Lumber, Banking, Information Technology, Medicine, Energy, Accounting Services, Legal, Retail, Professional Services, Business Services & Consulting

Malware: VECT Ransomware (VECT 2.0)

Attack: VECT is a Ransomware-as-a-Service (RaaS) operation that emerged in December 2025 and gained rapid reach through a mass affiliate model on BreachForums and a strategic partnership with the TeamPCP supply chain threat group. The malware targets Windows, Linux, and VMware ESXi environments using a C++ binary that incorporates a critically flawed ChaCha20-IETF encryption implementation. Due to a nonce-handling bug shared across all three platform variants, encompassing virtually all enterprise-critical data such as VM disks, databases, backups, and documents, is permanently and irrecoverably destroyed rather than encrypted. VECT effectively operates as a data wiper masquerading as ransomware, compounded by exfiltration threats and a growing affiliate distribution network.

✂ Attack Regions



Targeted

Non-Targeted



Attack Details

#1

VECT, now rebranded as VECT 2.0, is an emerging Ransomware-as-a-Service (RaaS) group that rapidly escalated its operations through February 2026. Active since December 2025, the group operates a custom-built C++ codebase and follows an explicit model to maximize disruption and financial gain. VECT's initial access strategy is diverse and opportunistic, leveraging multiple entry vectors across its broad affiliate base, compromised credentials, exposed remote services such as RDP and VPN, and phishing campaigns.

#2

Most notably, VECT formed a partnership with TeamPCP, a threat group behind a series of supply chain attacks in early 2026 that injected malicious code into widely used developer tools including Aqua Security's Trivy, Checkmarx's KICS, LiteLLM, and Telnix giving VECT affiliates pre-existing access to a large pool of compromised enterprise environments. VECT also partnered with BreachForums, granting every registered member automatic access to its ransomware builder, negotiation platform, and leak site, dramatically lowering the barrier to entry overnight.

#3

Following initial access, the malware executes a structured impact chain across all supported platforms. On Windows, the locker enumerates all logical, removable, and network-mapped drives, terminates processes holding file locks, and renames each targeted file with the '.vect' extension before encryption. When the '--force-safemode' flag is active, it modifies the boot configuration via 'bcdedit' to reboot into Safe Mode. It writes its path to the Windows registry for automatic execution on the next boot, where most security products are inactive.

#4

Post-encryption cleanup includes shadow copy deletion, clearing the event log, removing PowerShell history, and a self-deletion script. For lateral movement, the Windows locker uses multiple encoded remote-execution script templates driven by operator-supplied credentials. The Linux variant shares the ESXi codebase and implements a comparable subset of this functionality. A fundamental flaw in VECT's encryption engine, present identically across all three platform variants, causes three of four decryption nonces to be permanently discarded for every file exceeding 128 KB. Given that virtually all enterprise-critical files exceed this threshold, VECT functions in practice as a destructive data wiper rather than recoverable ransomware.

#5

VECT's ransom note claims exfiltration of sensitive data including databases, backups, and personal information; however, a dedicated exfiltration binary listed in the affiliate panel was marked "coming soon" and unavailable at the time of analysis. Ransom negotiations occur through a Tor hidden service, with a secondary contact via QtoX. Payments are enforced exclusively in Monero (XMR) for financial anonymity. Affiliates receive an 80% commission share, tracked through a built-in earnings dashboard with a \$1,000 minimum transfer threshold. As of February 28, 2026, the group's Tor-hosted Data Leak Site reported 20 active victim cases spanning manufacturing, education, healthcare, and technology sectors, with Brazil and the United States as the most heavily targeted countries.

Recommendations



Rotate Credentials on TeamPCP-Exposed Systems: Organizations that used Trivy, KICS, LiteLLM, or Telnix in their pipelines prior to March 2026 should treat those environments as potentially compromised. Rotate all service account credentials, API keys, and privileged account passwords immediately and audit for unauthorized access or persistence.



Monitor for Safe Mode Boot Tampering: Deploy detection rules to alert on `bcdedit /set safeboot` command execution and unexpected system reboots into Safe Mode, which VECT uses as a defense evasion mechanism to run its payload with security software disabled.



Monitor and Alert on Shadow Copy Deletion: Implement real-time alerts on `vssadmin delete shadows` commands and Windows VSS service termination. These are strong indicators of active ransomware execution and should trigger immediate incident response.



Harden SSH Access on Linux and ESXi Environments: Audit and remove unauthorized SSH public keys from all Linux and ESXi hosts. Enable SSH host key verification and restrict SSH access to explicitly approved management hosts only, limiting the SSH-based lateral movement capability.



Restrict WMI, DCOM, and PowerShell Remoting: Limit WMI and DCOM access to authorized management systems using firewall rules and Windows Firewall policies. Disable PowerShell remoting on hosts where it is not operationally required, and monitor for unusual remote execution from non-standard source systems.



Potential MITRE ATT&CK TTPs

Tactic	Technique	Sub-technique
Initial Access	<u>T1078</u> : Valid Accounts	
	<u>T1133</u> : External Remote Services	
	<u>T1566</u> : Phishing	
	<u>T1195</u> : Supply Chain Compromise	<u>T1195.002</u> : Compromise Software Supply Chain
Execution	<u>T1059</u> : Command and Scripting Interpreter	
Persistence	<u>T1053</u> : Scheduled Task/Job	<u>T1053.005</u> : Scheduled Task
	<u>T1547</u> : Boot or Logon Autostart Execution	<u>T1547.001</u> : Registry Run Keys / Startup Folder
Defense Evasion	<u>T1562</u> : Impair Defenses	<u>T1562.009</u> : Safe Mode Boot
		<u>T1562.001</u> : Disable or Modify Tools
	<u>T1070</u> : Indicator Removal	<u>T1070.001</u> : Clear Windows Event Logs
		<u>T1070.004</u> : File Deletion
	<u>T1027</u> : Obfuscated Files or Information	
Privilege Escalation	<u>T1134</u> : Access Token Manipulation	
Credential Access	<u>T1003</u> : OS Credential Dumping	
Discovery	<u>T1046</u> : Network Service Discovery	
	<u>T1082</u> : System Information Discovery	
	<u>T1083</u> : File and Directory Discovery	



Tactic	Technique	Sub-technique
Lateral Movement	T1021: Remote Services	T1021.002: SMB/Windows Admin Shares
		T1021.006: Windows Remote Management
		T1021.004: SSH
Collection	T1005: Data from Local System	
	T1039: Data from Network Shared Drive	
Command and Control	T1071: Application Layer Protocol	T1071.001: Web Protocols
	T1573: Encrypted Channel	
Exfiltration	T1041: Exfiltration Over C2 Channel	
Impact	T1486: Data Encrypted for Impact	
	T1490: Inhibit System Recovery	
	T1489: Service Stop	
	T1485: Data Destruction	

✂ Indicators of Compromise (IOCs)

TYPE	VALUE
SHA256	a7eadcf81dd6fda0dd6affefaffcb33b1d8f64ddec6e5a1772d028ef2a7da0f2, 58e17dd61d4d55fa77c7f2dd28dd51875b0ce900c1e43b368b349e65f27d6fdd, e1fc59c7ece6e9a7fb262fc8529e3c4905503a1ca44630f9724b2ccc518d0c06, 8ee4ec425bc0d8db050d13bbff98f483fff020050d49f40c5055ca2b9fb1c4d, 9c745f95a09b37bc0486bf0f92aad4a3d5548a939c086b93d6235d34648e683f, e512d22d2bd989f35ebaccb63615434870dc0642b0f60e6d4bda0bb89adee27a
IPv4:Port	158[.]94[.]210[.]11[::]8000
FileName	svc_host_update.exe, enc_esxi.elf, !!!READ_ME!!!.txt, VECT_RECOVERY_GUIDE.txt, README_VECT.html, dvm3_wall.bmp
File Extension	.vect
Email Address	Qilin[@]exploit[.]im
Tor Address	vectordntlcrImfkcm4alni734tbcrnd5lk44v6sp4lqal6noqrgrnbyd[.]onion



Recent Breaches

<https://www.guesty.com/>
<https://www.spglobal.com/en>
<https://verlatenergy.com/>
<https://usha.com/>
<https://www.pappytech.com/>
<https://www.keliweb.it/>
<https://jdaas.com/>
<https://susinsumos.com/>
<https://delreyservicos.com.br/>
<https://360.com/>
<https://mbcontabilidade.com.br/>
<https://apexhospitals.com/>
<https://www.auvo.com/>
<https://enertec.co.za/>
<https://grupoverdeazul.com/>
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